A Linguistic Research Profile of the Toto Language

General Overview

This section establishes the fundamental identity of the Toto language and its speakers, covering its genetic classification, demographic status, and ethnohistorical context.

Language Family Classification

The Toto language is definitively classified within the **Sino-Tibetan** macro-family.[1] Within this phylum, it belongs to the

Tibeto-Burman branch, a classification established by early influential linguists such as Hodgson and Grierson.[1]

The precise subgrouping of Toto within Tibeto-Burman remains a subject of scholarly refinement. Grierson (1909), in his *Linguistic Survey of India*, placed Toto within the "non-pronominalized Himalayan" group, based on features such as its numeral system and pronoun structure.[3] More recent scholarship, particularly work associated with SIL International and the Endangered Languages Project, classifies Toto within a

Dhimalish subgroup, often alongside the Dhimal language of Nepal.[1] This Dhimalish branch is sometimes posited as part of a larger, more speculative

Sal grouping of languages; van Driem (1995) has presented lexical evidence to support this hypothesis.[1] While some sources note vocabulary similarities with Munda (Austro-Asiatic) languages (e.g.,

apa 'father', *ayu* 'mother'), this is not considered evidence of a genetic link but rather of areal contact or coincidence, and the Tibeto-Burman classification is uncontested.[3]

The classification of Toto is not merely a static academic exercise but an active area of research. Its placement highlights a crucial area for comparative-historical linguistics. The established relationship with Dhimal and the more recent proposal to include the Lhokpu language of Bhutan in this group suggest the existence of a Lhokpu-Dhimal-Toto triad within the broader Trans-Himalayan (Sino-Tibetan) family.[10] This phylogenetic puzzle underscores the importance of detailed documentation of Toto, as new data on its grammar and lexicon can directly contribute to resolving questions about the deep history and branching of this part of the Sino-Tibetan tree.

Comparative Dat

Toto's primary genetic relatives are other Tibeto-Burman languages. Its closest attested relative is Dhimal, spoken in Nepal.[10] The proposed Lhokpu-Dhimal-Toto group would extend this immediate family into Bhutan.[10] Its primary contact languages, which are not genetically related, are from the Indo-Aryan family: Nepali and Bengali.[12] Dzongkha, a Southern Tibetic language spoken in Bhutan, also represents a relevant contact language due to geographical and historical proximity.[1]

ISO & Glottolog Codes

- **ISO 639-3 Code:** txo [1]
- **Glottolog Code:** toto1302 [1]

These standardized identifiers are crucial for distinguishing the Sino-Tibetan Toto language of India from unrelated, similarly named languages, such as the Totonacan languages of Mexico (Glottolog: toto1251, toto1252).[15]

Speaker Population

The demographic history of the Toto people reveals a significant recovery from a mid-20th-century population bottleneck, yet the number of fluent speakers remains critically low.

- **Historical Estimates:** Census data for the Toto *people* shows a steady increase over the last century.
  - 1901: 171 speakers were recorded.[6]
  - 1951: The population reached a nadir of 321 individuals living in 69 houses, a point where the tribe was considered to be nearing extinction.[7]
  - 1991: The population had recovered to 926 people.[7]
  - 2001: The number increased further to 1,184 people, all residing in Totopara.[7]
- **Current Estimates:** Recent estimates for the number of *speakers* of the language converge in the range of 1,400 to 1,600.
  - Estimates from the 2010s place the number at approximately 1,400 (Anderson, 2013) to 1,411 (2014).[1]
  - News reports and community-based sources from 2023–2024 consistently cite a figure of around 1,600 speakers.[5]

- UNESCO maintains a more conservative estimate of approximately 1,000 speakers.[1]
- *Note on Contested Data:* Earlier sources citing a population of 20,000 (King, 1994) are considered outliers and inconsistent with all other available demographic data.[8]

This data presents a critical paradox: while the Toto ethnic group has successfully recovered demographically, their language has simultaneously entered a phase of extreme endangerment. The very factors that have likely contributed to the community's survival and growth—such as increased integration into the regional economy, improved access to the outside world, and the settlement of other communities in Totopara—are the same factors that have eroded the linguistic isolation necessary for the language's vitality. This decoupling of ethnic and linguistic survival is a central theme in the modern context of the Toto language.

Geographic Distribution

The Toto language is geographically one of the most concentrated languages in the world.

- **Primary Location:** It is spoken almost exclusively in the village of **Totopara**, located in the Madarihat-Birpara administrative block of Alipurduar district, West Bengal, India.[1]
- **Coordinates:** The village is situated at approximately 26.83◦N 89.31◦E.[20]
- **Geographic Context:** Totopara is a remote hamlet of about 8.08 km^2 nestled in the foothills of the Himalayas, directly on the India-Bhutan border.[1] It is geographically bounded by the Bhutanese foothills to the north, the Torsa River to the east, and the Titi Reserve Forest and Hauri River to the southwest.[20] The nearest town, Madarihat, is 22 km away.[7]
- **Internal Divisions:** The village itself is subdivided into six hamlets (*gaons*): Panchayatgaon, Mandolgaon, Subbagaon, Mitranggaon, Pujagaon, and Dumchigaon.[6]

UNESCO Language Vitality Classification & Factors Contributing to Endangerment

- **Classification:** Toto is unequivocally classified as a **Critically Endangered**

language by UNESCO.[1] Ethnologue, using the EGIDS scale, rates it as "Endangered," a stage defined by the cessation of normal intergenerational transmission to children.[24]

- **Factors Contributing to Endangerment:** The endangerment of Toto is a result of multiple, compounding pressures:
  1. **Dominance of Contact Languages:** The primary threat is the pervasive influence of regional lingua francas, particularly **Nepali and Bengali**, which dominate all public domains, including education, administration, and commerce.[12]
  2. **Lack of Formal Education in Toto:** Toto is not used as a medium of instruction in schools. Children are educated in Bengali, which alienates them from literacy in their mother tongue and reduces the prestige of Toto.[1]
  3. **Limited Government Support:** The language is not listed in the Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution, precluding it from official status and dedicated central government funding for promotion.[13] Furthermore, India's census policy of not officially listing languages with fewer than 10,000 speakers renders Toto invisible in national statistics, further marginalizing it from policy considerations.[12]
  4. **Socioeconomic Pressures:** Migration for work and increasing integration into the mainstream economy necessitate the use of dominant languages, weakening the domains where Toto is used.[13]
  5. **Demographic Shift:** The historical isolation of Totopara has ended. Significant migration of Nepali-speaking communities, particularly following their expulsion from Bhutan in the 1990s, has made the Toto people a minority in their own village, intensifying language contact and pressure to shift.[22]

Origins & Migration History of the Toto People

The ethnohistory of the Toto people is obscure due to a lack of written records and well-documented oral traditions regarding their migration.[19] The historical narrative is largely a reconstruction based on anthropological evidence and regional histories.

The Totos are considered a Mongoloid people belonging to the Tibeto-Burman group.[19] Their ancestors are believed to have migrated into the Himalayan foothills from the north, possibly from areas in or around Tibet and Bhutan. Historical theories suggest that their final settlement in Totopara was the result of displacement. One prominent theory posits that the Totos moved south from Bhutan around the mid-18th century to escape conflict with the more powerful Bhutia people.[22] Another account

specifies a conflict with the Doya tribe of Bhutan as the catalyst for their migration into their present location.[23]

It is estimated that the Totos settled in the secluded area of Totopara at least eight to ten generations ago.[19] This choice of location was likely a defensive strategy to preserve their ethnic and linguistic identity by avoiding absorption into larger, more dominant communities.[19] The region was politically part of Bhutan until the conclusion of the Anglo-Bhutan War in 1865, after which it was ceded to British India.[19]

Phonolog

The sound system of Toto is characteristic of its Tibeto-Burman heritage but exhibits at least one major point of contention in the existing linguistic literature regarding its prosodic system.

Vowel Inventory

Toto is described as having a system of six monophthongs and eight diphthongs.[1] The primary analysis comes from Basumatary (2014), based on direct fieldwork.[6]

- **Monophthongs:** The six vowel phonemes are /i,e,ə,a,o,u/.[1] These can be classified by height (high, mid, low) and backness (front, central, back).

Table 1: Toto Vowel Inventory (IPA)

	Front	Central	Back
High	i		u
Mid	e	ə	o
Low		a	

- **Diphthongs:** Eight diphthongs have been identified: /eu/,/au/,/ou/,/ei/,/əi/,/ai/,/oi/,/ui/.[1] Their distribution varies; for instance, /ui/ can occur in initial, medial, and final positions, while /au/ and /ou/ are restricted to medial positions.[1]
- **Other Features:**

- **Nasalization:** Vowel nasalization occurs and appears to be phonologically significant, as in the word *tũ* 'six', though its status as a distinct set of phonemes versus an allophonic feature is not fully resolved.[3]
- **Breathy Vowels:** The proposal for encoding the Toto script in Unicode provides evidence for at least one contrast involving a breathy vowel, /æ̤puwɑ/ 'decay', suggesting the vowel system may be more complex than the six-vowel model indicates.[29]

Consonant Inventory

The language has an inventory of 19 consonant phonemes, comprising 12 obstruents (stops and fricatives) and 7 sonorants (nasals, liquids, and approximants).[1] A key feature is the phonemic contrast between unaspirated and aspirated voiceless stops at the bilabial and alveolar places of articulation (

/p/ vs. /ph/, /t/ vs. /th/).[1]

Table 2: Toto Consonant Inventory (IPA)

	Bilabial	Alveolar	Palatal	Velar	Glottal
Stop	p ph b	t th d	c ɟ	k g	
Fricative		s			h
Nasal	m	n		ŋ	
Approximant		l	j		
Trill		r			

Note: The symbols c *and* ɟ *represent voiceless and voiced palatal stops, respectively.*

Tone/Pitch-Accent System

The nature of the prosodic system in Toto is a major point of contradiction in the available literature and represents a critical area for future research.

- **Evidence for a Tonal System:** A comparative study by Barman et al. (2025) explicitly identifies Toto as a tonal language, stating that it uses pitch (high, mid, and low tones) to distinguish word meaning. This is presented as a primary phonological feature differentiating it from the non-tonal Indo-Aryan language Rajbanshi.[30]
- **Evidence Against a Tonal System:** In direct opposition, a grammar sketch on the SIL-affiliated Webonary platform and a numeral database both describe Toto as "nontonal" or "toneless".[31]

This discrepancy is significant. It is unlikely to be a simple error, given the credibility of the sources. It may stem from different analytical frameworks, where one group of researchers analyzes a pitch-accent system as "tonal" while another does not. Alternatively, it could reflect a system in flux, where tonal contrasts are being lost under the influence of non-tonal contact languages, making the system ambiguous and difficult to classify. This debate highlights the methodological challenges in documenting the prosody of under-described languages and underscores the need for instrumental phonetic analysis of pitch contours in Toto.

Phonotactic Rules & Constraints

Toto exhibits a strong preference for simple syllable structures, primarily **CV** (consonant-vowel) and **CVC**.[30] It systematically avoids complex consonant clusters, a phonotactic constraint that clearly distinguishes it from neighboring Indo-Aryan languages like Bengali and Rajbanshi, which permit such clusters.[30] This structural preference is a robust feature of the language's phonological grammar.

Contact-Induced Phonetic Changes

The phonotactic constraints of Toto directly influence how it integrates loanwords. When borrowing words from Bengali or Nepali that contain consonant clusters, Toto speakers systematically adapt these words to fit their native CV(C) syllable structure by simplifying the clusters.[30] This process of phonological adaptation demonstrates the resilience of the language's core sound structure. Even as the lexicon is open to external influence, foreign words are reshaped to conform to Toto's native phonological rules. This filtering mechanism acts as a powerful, albeit subconscious, form of structural preservation.

Morphology

Toto is typologically an agglutinative language, primarily using suffixes and particles to build words and express grammatical relationships.[30] This contrasts with the fusional and inflectional morphology more typical of its Indo-Aryan neighbors.

Word Formation Processes

The primary morphological process is suffixation, particularly for marking nominal cases and some verbal categories.[26] However, the language also employs periphrastic constructions, using separate particles or lexemes to mark categories like future tense and the genitive case.[26] This combination of synthetic (agglutinative) and analytic strategies creates a mixed morphological system. This system may reflect an internal evolutionary path or, potentially, the influence of contact with analytic-leaning Indo-Aryan languages.

Case System

The nominal case system in Toto has been described in detail by Saha (2019).[26] It marks the grammatical and semantic roles of noun phrases in a clause.

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Table 3: The Toto Case System

Case	Marker/Strategy	Example Sentence	Gloss
Nominative	Unmarked (ø)	*ka torʃe cədaŋ-mi*	1SG mango like-PRS ('I like mango.')
Accusative	Suffix: /–ko/	*apa… ceŋʋa-ko lagi copa-na*	father… son-ACC for.POSTP buy-PST.PRF ('Father bought a toy for his son.')
Instrumental	Suffix: /–so/	*aku… ɖupe-so nedina*	3SG… axe-INS cut-PST ('He cut the tree with an axe.')
Ablative	Suffix: /–ʃu/	*radha… ʃa-ʃu no-na*	Radha… house-ABL leave-PST ('Radha just went from the house.')
Locative	Suffix: /–ta/	*kuŋ joŋbri skul-ta ni-na*	1SG.GEN sister school-LOC be-PST ('My sister is in the school.')
Genitive	Separate Lexeme	*kuŋ joŋbri…*	1SG.GEN sister… ('My sister…')
Benefactive	Postposition: /lagi/	*…ceŋʋa-ko lagi copa-na*	…son-ACC for.POSTP buy-PST.PRF ('…for his son.')

Verb Morphology

Detailed information on verb morphology is less complete than for the case system, with some data available from Chakrabarty (2006) via the Grambank database.[33]

- **Tense–Aspect–Mood (TAM) Marking:**

- **Tense:** The system is organized around a primary distinction between **future** and **non-future**.[33]
  - **Non-Future:** Marked with suffixes, including /–mi/, /–me/, and /–na/.[33]
  - **Future:** Marked with post-verbal particles, such as /ro/, /ko/, and /rowa/.[33]
- **Aspect:** A morphological distinction between **perfective and imperfective aspect** is available on verbs.[33] The specific markers for this distinction are not detailed in the available materials.
- **Mood:** Data on the marking of grammatical moods (e.g., imperative, subjunctive) is currently unavailable.

- **Agreement Rules:** A typologically significant feature of Toto is its reported **lack of verbal agreement** for person, number, or gender.[17] Many languages in the Tibeto-Burman family, particularly in the Kiranti branch, exhibit complex agreement systems. The absence of such a system in Toto is a crucial feature for its classification and for comparative studies with related languages like Dhimal and Lhokpu. It suggests that Toto may have lost an ancestral agreement system or belongs to a subgroup that never developed one.

Plural Formation Patterns

Nouns and pronouns can be marked for plurality. Two distinct markers have been reported:

- The suffix /–bi/ is used to form plurals of nouns and personal pronouns.[26]
- The word-particle *'ba'* is also cited as a plurality marker.[3]

  The relationship between these two markers (e.g., whether they are allomorphs, used in different contexts, or represent different analyses) is unclear and requires further investigation.

Syntax

The syntax of Toto is consistently head-final, a typological profile that aligns it with its Tibeto-Burman origins and distinguishes it from the head-initial structure of Bengali.

Canonical Word Order

The canonical word order in a transitive clause is **Subject-Object-Verb (SOV)**.[30] This order is reported to be fixed for core arguments and consistent across both main and subordinate clauses.[33] The SOV structure is the most common word order found cross-linguistically and is particularly prevalent throughout Asia and within the Tibeto-Burman language family.[35] This typological consistency suggests that the core syntactic template of Toto has remained stable and resistant to structural borrowing from neighboring SVO languages.

Noun Phrase Structure

The Toto noun phrase (NP) is rigidly head-final, with all modifiers preceding the head noun.[31]

- **Order of Modifiers:** The general structure places genitives, demonstratives, adjectives, and relative clauses before the noun they modify.[30]
- **Noun Classifiers:** A notable feature of the NP is the use of noun classifiers, which is typical for Tibeto-Burman languages.[30] These classifiers are required for numerals from one to ten, and the choice of classifier depends on the semantic category of the noun being counted (e.g., different classifiers for people, trees, eggs, or bamboo sticks).[32]

Verb Phrase Structure

As an SOV language, Toto uses **postpositions** instead of prepositions to mark relationships between the verb phrase and nominals.[31] Detailed information on the internal structure of the verb phrase, such as the relative ordering of adverbs, objects, and auxiliary verbs, is not available in the reviewed sources.

Clause Combining & Subordination

The mechanisms for creating complex sentences in Toto are not well-documented. Chakrabarty (2006) notes that clausal objects occupy the same pre-verbal position as nominal objects, which suggests that the SOV word order is maintained in sentences with embedded clauses.[33] However, specific subordinating conjunctions or relativization strategies are not described.

Negation Strategies

The strategy for verbal negation is an area with conflicting data, indicating a need for further fieldwork to resolve the discrepancy.

- One source describes negation as being marked by a prefix **an-** or a separate particle **anpo**.[30]
- Another source identifies the negative marker as a suffix, **-mɑ** or **-mo**, which attaches to the verb.[3]

  This contradiction between a pre-verbal (prefix/particle) and a post-verbal (suffix) strategy for the same core grammatical function is significant and requires clarification.

Semantics & Lexicon

The Toto lexicon reflects the community's unique cultural context, natural environment, and history of language contact.

Core Vocabulary

A list of core vocabulary items collected by van Driem (1995) provides a foundation for

understanding the language's basic lexicon.[1]

- **Pronouns:** *ka* 'I', *nati* 'thou'.
- **Nouns:** *ti* 'water', *saní* 'sun', *tarí* 'moon', *mico* 'eye', *nanuŋ* 'ear', *paká* 'pig', *kiya* 'dog', *ŋaya* 'fish', *luŋtü* 'stone'.
- **Verbs:** *ca-* 'eat', *aŋ-* 'to drink', *si-* 'die', *yuŋ-* 'sit, stay', *jiŋ-* 'sleep'.
- **Numerals:** The numeral system is vigesimal (base-20), a feature noted by Grierson.[3] Higher numbers are constructed based on multiples of twenty; for example, 100 is expressed as
  ŋakai ('five-twenty').[3] The suffix
  /–co/ is commonly attached to numeral roots (e.g., *icho* 'one', *nicho* 'two').[3] There is evidence, however, that Indo-Aryan loanwords are now used for some higher numbers, particularly from 11 upwards.[32]

Culturally Significant Semantic Domains

The lexicon contains words that are deeply embedded in the Toto worldview and social structure.

- **Religion and Social Structure:** Key cultural terms include the names of traditional deities, such as **Ishpa**, a spirit believed to reside in the Bhutan hills, and **Cheima**, the guardian goddess of the village.[7]
  Eu is the Toto word for the traditional rice liquor that plays a central role in religious offerings and social ceremonies.[7] The traditional village priest is known as the
  Kaji, and the secular headman is the **Mondal**.[37]
- **Kinship:** The language maintains specific kinship terminology, such as *iŋ* 'brother-in-law' and *luã* 'husband's elder brother's wife', reflecting the importance of extended family structures.[1]
- **Local Environment:** The vocabulary is rich in terms related to the local flora and fauna of the sub-Himalayan region, including words for specific species like *wɔteŋ* 'a species of bamboo' and *lapa* 'jungle betel leaf'.[1]

Loanword Sources, Frequency, Semantic Fields

Prolonged and intensive contact has led to significant borrowing from neighboring Indo-Aryan languages.

- **Primary Sources:** The dominant sources of loanwords are **Bengali** and **Nepali**.[17]
- **Semantic Fields of Borrowing:** Loanwords are common in modern domains such as education ('school') and medicine ('doctor').[30] More critically, borrowing is now encroaching upon the core domestic lexicon. There is a documented trend of native Toto words being replaced by Bengali equivalents for everyday concepts. For example, the Toto word *kaibu* ('step') is increasingly being replaced by the Bengali *shiri*, and *dui* ('veranda') is giving way to the Bengali *baranda*.[12]

This process of lexical replacement in the home domain is a strong diagnostic of advanced language shift. While borrowing words for new concepts is a common and often stable form of language contact, the replacement of core vocabulary for familiar, domestic items indicates that the domains of use for Toto are shrinking rapidly. This evidence suggests that the language is in a severe state of attrition, as the dominant contact languages are no longer just supplementing the Toto lexicon but actively supplanting it.

Comparative Data

Some lexical comparisons have been made with Dzongkha, the national language of Bhutan. For instance, the second syllable of the Toto word *yoti* ('cooking pot') is suggested to be cognate with Dzongkha *dî* ('jug'), pointing to historical contact.[1]

Sociolinguistic Profile

The sociolinguistic situation of Toto is defined by its confinement to a single community and the intense pressure from surrounding dominant languages, which severely restricts its domains of use and threatens its intergenerational transmission.

Domains of Use

The use of Toto is largely restricted to the private and community spheres.

- **Home and Village:** Toto remains the primary language of daily communication within the home and among community members in Totopara.[1] It is the "heartbeat of their daily communication".[17]
- **Education:** Toto has no official role in the education system. The medium of instruction in local government schools is Bengali, with English also being taught.[1] This creates a situation of diglossia where children use Toto at home and Bengali at school.
- **Religion:** Traditional rituals and ceremonies are likely domains for Toto use, though specific documentation on this is limited.
- **Trade and External Communication:** Outside the village, in markets or when interacting with non-Totos, speakers must use Bengali, Nepali, or Hindi.[12]

Code-Switching & Mixing Patterns

Due to pervasive bilingualism, code-switching and lexical borrowing are common. As noted previously, a concerning trend is the replacement of core Toto vocabulary with Bengali terms for everyday items like 'step' (*kaibu* → *shiri*) and 'veranda' (*dui* → *baranda*).[12] This indicates a shift from situational code-switching to a more permanent language shift at the lexical level.

Language Attitudes & Identity

Language attitudes within the Toto community are complex and reflect the pressures of marginalization.

- **Language as Identity:** There is a strong sense of Toto as a marker of unique cultural identity.[40] The development of a unique script has been a major source of community pride.[12]
- **Negative Attitudes:** At the same time, assimilation into the broader socio-cultural fabric has led to feelings of embarrassment or shame associated

with using Toto in the presence of outsiders who speak dominant languages.[17]
- **Pragmatism vs. Preservation:** Younger community members question the utility of learning Toto, asking if it will help them secure employment, a pragmatic concern in a region with limited economic opportunities.[40] Community elders like Dhaniram Toto counter this by emphasizing that the language is a "linguistic symbol" of their identity that must be protected regardless of its economic value.[39]

Intergenerational Transmission

The chain of intergenerational transmission is broken, which is the primary reason for the language's "Critically Endangered" status.

- While many children still learn Toto as their first language at home, this is no longer the norm for all children.[1]
- The lack of reinforcement in the educational system and the dominance of other languages in public life means that children's proficiency in Toto is often not fully developed, and their primary language for literacy and higher-level functions becomes Bengali.[17]
- The Anthropological Survey of India has noted a clear trend where the number of fluent Toto speakers is dwindling relative to the overall growth of the Toto population, indicating a failure of complete transmission from one generation to the next.[17]

Cultural & Folklore Context

The Toto language is the primary vehicle for the community's rich oral traditions, which have been the sole means of preserving their cultural knowledge for centuries.

Folk Tales, Songs, Proverbs, Oral Traditions

Toto possesses a rich repository of folk literature, including myths, legends, and songs, which has been passed down orally from generation to generation.[17] This oral tradition was largely unrecorded and unknown to the outside world until recent documentation efforts.

A significant contribution to the documentation of this tradition is the work of Bimalendu Majumdar, whose book, *A Sociological Study of the Toto Folk Tales*, presents 24 folk tales collected from community "tale-tellers" in the late 1970s.[41] The book includes analyses of the tales' sociological aspects and provides five of the tales in the original Toto language with English translations.[42] These tales cover a range of genres, including creation myths (e.g., "The Tale of the Birth of the Sun"), aetiological myths explaining natural phenomena ("Why Celestial Stars are Immortal," "Cause of Landslide in the Hills"), and legends about the origins of the thirteen Toto clans.[41]

However, this oral tradition is now facing rapid extinction due to the passing of the elder "tale-tellers" and the broader pressures of language shift.[41]

Culturally Unique Words

The Toto lexicon contains words that encapsulate specific cultural concepts with no direct one-to-one equivalent in English or Bengali.

- **Eu:** This term refers to the traditional, home-brewed liquor made from millet or rice. It is more than just an alcoholic beverage; it is an essential component of all religious rituals and offerings to deities like Ishpa and Cheima, and plays a central role in social life.[7]
- **Ishpa and Cheima:** These are the names of the chief deities in the traditional Toto pantheon. Ishpa is a male deity associated with the Bhutan hills who can cause sickness, while Cheima is a female deity who protects the village. Their names are integral to the community's spiritual vocabulary.[7]
- **Kaji and Mondal:** These terms refer to the two key leadership roles in traditional Toto society. The *Kaji* is the village priest, responsible for religious duties, while the *Mondal* is the secular chief.[37]
- **Demsha:** This is the name for the sacred house where the two sacred drums (*Bakung*), representing the deities Mahakal and Mahakali, are kept for annual worship.[37]

Language Contact & Change

The Toto language exists in a state of intense and asymmetrical contact with its larger, more dominant Indo-Aryan neighbors. This contact has profoundly shaped its lexicon and presents the greatest threat to its survival.

Influence from Nepali, Bengali, Dzongkha

The primary linguistic influences on Toto come from Nepali and Bengali.[17] Nepali is the dominant language spoken by the numerically larger non-Toto population within Totopara itself, making it the language of immediate, daily inter-community contact.[22] Bengali is the official language of the state of West Bengal, dominating administration, education, and media, and serves as the language of wider communication.[13] The influence of Hindi is also noted, likely as a pan-regional lingua franca.[12] Historical contact with Dzongkha, a Tibetic language of Bhutan, is also evident in some lexical items.[1]

Borrowed Structures & Vocabulary

The most visible effect of language contact is extensive lexical borrowing.

- **Vocabulary:** As discussed in the lexicon section, Toto has borrowed words for modern concepts like 'school' and 'doctor'.[30] More significantly, it is experiencing lexical replacement, where core vocabulary items are being supplanted by Bengali words (e.g.,
  kaibu > *shiri* 'step').[12]
- **Structures:** There is less evidence for the borrowing of grammatical structures. The core syntax remains robustly SOV and head-final, in contrast to Bengali's SVO structure. However, Barman et al. (2025) note that Toto's use of subordinate conjunctions like *je* ('that') and *jodi* ('if') shows similarity with Standard Bengali, suggesting some borrowing at the level of function words used for clause combining.[30]

Shifts in Grammar or Phonology Due to Contact

The primary documented shift is phonological adaptation. Borrowed words are systematically altered to fit Toto's native phonotactic constraints, such as the simplification of consonant clusters.[30] The contested status of the language's tonal system could also be a result of contact-induced change, with the language potentially losing tonal distinctions under the influence of non-tonal Nepali and Bengali. However, this remains speculative without further research. The overall grammatical system, particularly its agglutinative morphology and head-final syntax, appears to be more resistant to change than the lexicon.

Writing & Orthography

For most of its history, Toto was an exclusively oral language. The development of writing systems is a very recent phenomenon, driven by community efforts to preserve the language and culture.

Historical Orthographic Practices

There are no historical orthographic practices for Toto. Until 2015, when community members wished to write their language, they primarily used the **Bengali (Eastern Nagari) script**.[1] However, the Bengali script is phonologically inadequate for Toto, as it cannot represent certain unique sounds of the language, such as the nasal consonant /ŋ/ or potential distinctions like breathy vowels.[10]

Current Writing Systems

- **Toto Script:** A unique alphabetic script for the language was created by community elder and author **Dhaniram Toto** and was officially launched on May 22, 2015.[1] The creation of this script was a landmark event for the community, providing a sense of pride, status, and a tool for accurate linguistic representation.[12] The script is an alphabet and does not have an inherent vowel.[29]
- **Bengali Script:** Despite the existence of the new script, the Bengali script remains in common use, particularly among older community members who are more familiar with it.[18] The first Toto dictionary, *Toto Shabda Sangraha*, was published using the Bengali script to ensure its accessibility.[5]

- **Romanization:** The Latin script is also used, particularly in linguistic documentation and academic contexts.[4]

Standardization Efforts

The most significant standardization effort has been the successful encoding of the Toto script in the **Unicode Standard**. A proposal was submitted in 2019, and the script was officially added in Unicode Version 14.0 in September 2021.[1] This is a crucial step for enabling digital use of the language, including creating fonts (like Noto Serif Toto), keyboard layouts, and other software support.[47]

Despite this progress, standardization challenges remain, including the consistent representation of features like elision, word breaks, long vowels, and punctuation.[10]

Preservation & Documentation Efforts

Awareness of Toto's endangered status has spurred a number of documentation and revitalization initiatives, driven by both the community itself and external academic institutions.

Academic, Community, and NGO Projects

- **Academic Research:**
  - The **Anthropological Survey of India (AnSI)** has conducted studies on the Toto language, highlighting its endangered status and documenting its vocabulary and oral traditions.[17]
  - The **Himalayan Languages Project** has worked on creating the first grammatical sketch of Toto.[18]
  - The **University of Calcutta**, in collaboration with the trust **Calcutta Comparatists 1919**, has been instrumental in supporting the publication of Toto language materials, including the *Toto Shabda Sangraha* dictionary and novels by Dhaniram Toto.[12] Their stated goal is to save marginal languages from extinction.[18]
  - Linguists such as **Toby Anderson** have worked directly with the community, contributing to phonological notes and speaker estimates.[8]

- **Community-Led Initiatives:**
  - The **Chittaranjan Toto Memorial Education Centre**, a privately run primary school in Totopara, is a key hub for language revitalization.[40] Established in 2014, it is the only institution that actively teaches the Toto language and its new script to children.[40]
  - The **Toto Kalyan Samity** (Committee for the Preservation of Toto Language and Culture), led by Dhaniram Toto, has been central to advocacy and preservation efforts.[8]
  - The **"Tunthungkamu – The Story of the Totos"** is a workshop and festival organized collaboratively by the Chittaranjan Toto Memorial Education Centre and other foundations to promote cultural immersion and support the community's preservation initiatives.[48]

Digital Dictionaries, Corpora, Teaching Materials

- **Digital Dictionaries:**
  - **Webonary:** SIL International hosts an online Toto-English dictionary on its Webonary platform. As of October 2024, this "rough draft" version contains 796 entries in Toto and is written in the new Toto script, as well as Bengali and Latin scripts.[4]
  - ***Toto Shabda Sangraha*:** Published in October 2023, this is the first comprehensive print dictionary of the language. Compiled by community member Bhakta Toto with support from the University of Calcutta, it is a trilingual (Toto-Bengali-English) dictionary containing around 1,200 words.[12] It uses the Bengali script for accessibility.
- **Corpora:** There is no mention of a large-scale, publicly accessible digital corpus of Toto text or audio recordings in the reviewed materials. Documentation projects by AnSI and others have likely created archival recordings, but their format and accessibility are not specified.
- **Teaching Materials:**
  - A **primer** for the Toto script was published in early 2023.[43]
  - The Alipurduar district administration has printed 500 **practice notebooks** for children to learn to trace the Toto alphabet, which are used at the Chittaranjan Toto Memorial Education Centre.[40]

Recommendations from Linguists for Revitalization

While specific recommendations for Toto from named linguists are not detailed, a general framework for language revitalization can be constructed based on best practices and the specific challenges facing the Toto community.

1. **Strengthen Intergenerational Transmission:** This is the most critical factor. The **Master-Apprentice Program** model, which pairs fluent elders with motivated adult learners for intensive immersion, could be highly effective in creating new fluent speakers.[55] Efforts should also focus on encouraging and supporting parents to use Toto exclusively with their young children in the home.[56]
2. **Expand Domains of Use, Starting with Education:**
   - **Language Nests:** Establishing community-run preschools or childcare centers where Toto is the sole medium of communication ("language nests") would create an immersion environment for the youngest generation.[55]
   - **Formal Education:** The community should continue to advocate for the inclusion of Toto as a subject or medium of instruction in local government schools. Developing a standardized curriculum and more advanced teaching materials (beyond alphabet books) is essential for this.[13]
3. **Develop and Disseminate High-Quality Materials:**
   - **Literacy Materials:** Building on the new script and dictionary, the community and supporting linguists should focus on creating a body of literature, including graded readers for children, collections of folk tales, and original creative writing.[58]
   - **Digital Resources:** Leveraging the Unicode-encoded script, developing mobile apps, online learning platforms, and a more comprehensive digital dictionary with audio pronunciations would engage younger, tech-savvy generations.[13]
4. **Documentation and Standardization:**
   - **Comprehensive Grammar:** A top priority for academic partners should be the production of a comprehensive, modern descriptive grammar of Toto. This would resolve contradictions in the existing literature (e.g., regarding tone and negation) and provide a stable foundation for all teaching materials.
   - **Audio-Visual Corpus:** Creating a publicly accessible digital archive of high-quality audio and video recordings of natural speech, storytelling, and cultural events is crucial for preserving the language for future generations and for linguistic research.[56]
5. **Foster Community Pride and Ownership:** Revitalization efforts are most successful when they are community-driven. Supporting initiatives like the Chittaranjan Toto Memorial Education Centre and empowering community

members like Dhaniram Toto and Bhakta Toto to lead projects ensures that the efforts are culturally appropriate and sustainable.[40]

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